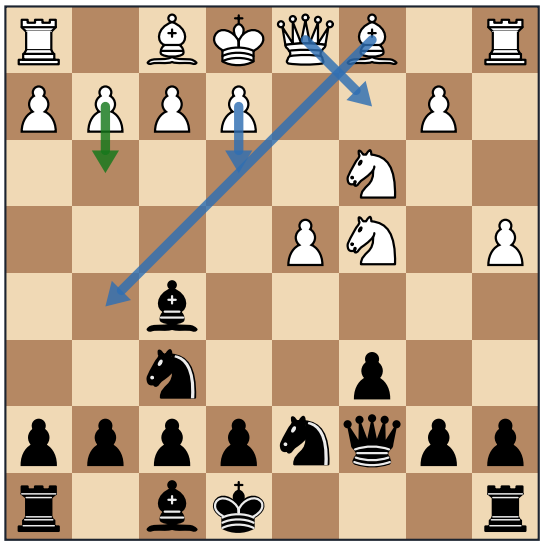
Slav Defense

ECO D10-D19 | 52 named lines | Queen's Gambit / Slav family

In one sentence: The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Memory pattern: c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.Ne5 Nbd7 7.Nxc4 Qc7

Key ideas

1. Challenge d5 with c4: if Black takes (QGA), White regains the pawn and gets center.
2. QGD: Black holds d5 with ...e6; the light bishop is the problem piece.
3. Slav: ...c6 keeps the light bishop free for ...Bf5.
4. Exchange Carlsbad: White plays the minority attack b4-b5; Black counters with ...Ne4 and ...f5.
5. Black's freeing moves are ...c5 and ...e5; White's are e4 and Qc2/Bd3 kingside play.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.58** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best: g3.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.
2. Where does my king go?	Both sides castle kingside; the king is rarely attacked early.
3. Best minor pieces?	White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3/Nf3, Bd3, Rc1. Black: Nbd7, Bb7 or Bf5, Be7, Rc8.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

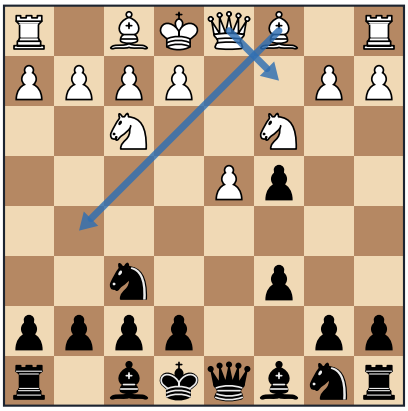
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.Ne5 Nbd7 7.Nxc4 Qc7

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Hold the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. c4	Attack d5. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... c6	Slav setup. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
3... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
4. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
4... dxc4	Take the pawn. Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
5. a4	Gains space on the wing.
5... Bf5	Develop outside the chain.
6. Ne5	Repositions the knight to a more active square.
6... Nbd7	Develops the knight to d7.
7. Nxc4	Captures on c4 to trade or win material.
7... Qc7	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).



After 1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6



After 6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

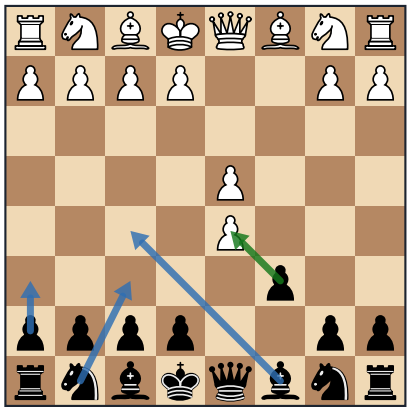


Position after the line

Czech Variation D17 | 13 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5`

Stockfish: **+0.35** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Carlsbad Variation, Krause Attack, Wiesbaden Variation, Classical System

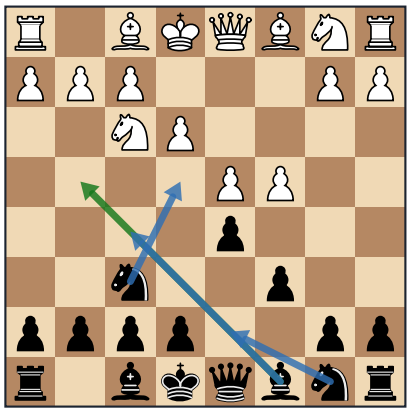


Position after the line

Exchange Variation D10 | 6 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.cxd5`

Stockfish: **+0.33** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: cxd5.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Boor Attack, Schallopp Variation, Symmetrical Line, Trifunovic Variation

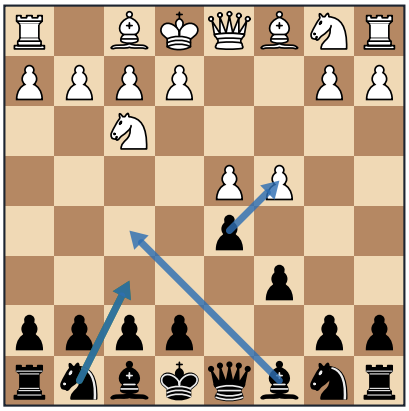


Position after the line

Quiet Variation D11 | 6 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3`

Stockfish: **+0.29** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Bg4.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Schallopp Defense, Pin Defense, Amsterdam Variation, Landau Variation

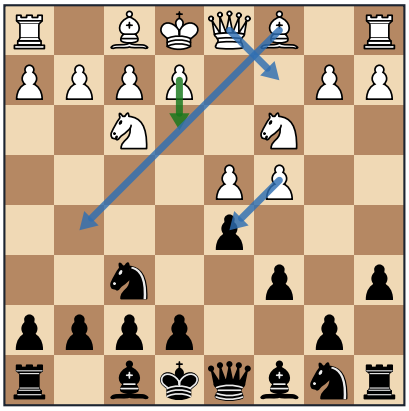


Position after the line

Modern Line D11 | 4 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.37** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)

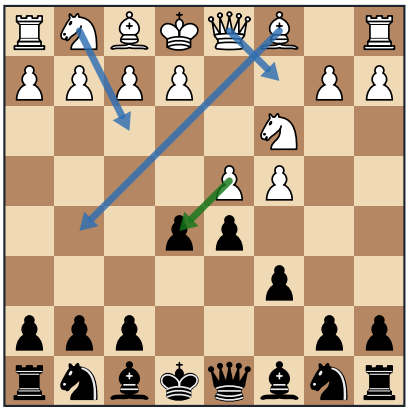


Position after the line

Chebanenko Variation D15 | 3 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 a6`

Stockfish: **+0.40** (slightly better for White, depth 14). Best next move: e3.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Advance System



Position after the line

Winawer Countergambit D10 | 2 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 e5`

Stockfish: **+0.48** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: dxe5.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Anti-Winawer Gambit

Detailed repertoire notes

Slav / Semi-Slav (D10-D19, D43-D49, Black)

```
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.e3 e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O Nbd7 9.Qe2 Bg6 10.e4 O-O 11.Bd3
Bh5 12.Bg5 Qa5
```

Idea: Support d5 with c6, develop the light bishop outside the chain, then ...e6.

Structure: Slav: c6/d5 pawns with an active c8 bishop. Semi-Slav: e6/c6/d5 chain with ...dxc4 and ...b5 break.

Pieces: Bf5/g4 outside the chain, knight d7/f6, Bb4 or e7, queen c7/b6.

Plan: Gain the center with ...e5 or ...c5; use the bishop pair and the b5 break in the Semi-Slav.

King: Castle after ...e6 and ...Be7; keep ...Bf5 outside the chain. **Opponent:** e4 to grab the center, a4 to hold c4; Black wants ...e5 or ...c5.

Watch out: Do not overextend the queen side; White's e4 can be dangerous if Black falls behind in development.

Expert and coach view

Capablanca and Karpov played the Queen's Gambit Declined with great success.

What a coach would tell you

Know the three structures: Carlsbad (minority attack), IQP (attack vs blockade) and hanging pawns. Study the plans for each, then choose the QGD, Slav or QGA based on your style.

Why play it

The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Typical mistakes

• Taking on c4 without a plan to hold the pawn (...b5) or return it.

• Playing Bg5 too early or Nf3 too early without considering ...Ne4 or ...c5.

• Ignoring the minority attack and allowing a permanently weak c6 pawn.

Typical tactics and traps

• Elephant Trap: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5 6.Nxd5? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+ and Black wins.

• Back-rank tactics when queens trade and the rooks are unconnected.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

QGD endings are usually balanced; Black's solid structure makes winning chances hard for White.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Slav Defense (all lines)** — D10
  `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6`
  - **Diemer Gambit** — D10
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.e4`
  - **Exchange Variation** — D10
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.cxd5`
    - **Boor Attack** — D10
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.cxd5 -> 3...cxd5 4.Nc3 Nf6 5.f3`
    - **Schallopp Variation** — D13
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 Bf5 5.cxd5 cxd5 6.Nc3`
    - **Symmetrical Line** — D14
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.cxd5 -> 3...cxd5 4.Nc3 Nf6 5.Nf3 Nc6 6.Bf4 Bf5`
    - **Trifunovic Variation** — D14
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.cxd5 cxd5 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Bf4 Bf5 7.e3 e6 8.Qb3 Bb4`
  - **Modern Line** — D11
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3`
  - **Winawer Countergambit** — D10
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nc3 e5`
    - **Anti-Winawer Gambit** — D10
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 e5 -> 4.e4`
  - **Bonet Gambit** — D11
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Bg5`
  - **Breyer Variation** — D11
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nbd2`
  - **Quiet Variation** — D11
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3`
    - **Pin Defense** — D11
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 -> 4...Bg4`
    - **Schallopp Defense** — D12
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 -> 4...Bf5`
    - **Amsterdam Variation** — D12
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 -> 4...Bf5 5.cxd5 cxd5 6.Nc3 e6 7.Ne5 Nfd7`
    - **Landau Variation** — D12
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 -> 4...Bf5 5.cxd5 cxd5 6.Qb3 Qc8 7.Bd2 e6 8.Na3`
  - **Slav Gambit** — D10
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nc3 dxc4 4.e4`
    - **Alekhine Attack** — D10
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nc3 dxc4 4.e4`
  - **Three Knights Variation** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3`
  - **Chebanenko Variation** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 a6`
    - **Advance System** — D15
      `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 a6 -> 5.c5`
  - **Schlechter Variation** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 g6`
  - **Süchting Variation** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 Qb6`
  - **Two Knights Attack** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4`
  - **Alapin Variation** — D16
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4`
  - **Alekhine Variation** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.e3`
  - **Geller Gambit** — D15
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.e4`
  - **Czech Variation** — D17
    `1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5`

- **Bled Attack** D17
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.Nh4
- **Classical System** D18
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.e3
  - **Main Line** D19
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.e3 -> 6...e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O O-O 9.Qe2
- **Krause Attack** D17
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.Ne5
  - **Fazekas Gambit** D17
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.Ne5 -> 6...Na6 7.e4
- **Lasker Variation** D18
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.e3 Na6
- **Wiesbaden Variation** D17
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.Ne5 e6
  - **Sharp Line** D17
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.Ne5 e6 -> 7.f3 Bb4 8.e4
- **Dutch Variation** D19
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.e3 e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O
  - **Sämisch Variation** D19
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.e3 e6 7.Bxc4 Bb4 8.O-O -> 8...O-O 9.Qe2 Ne4 10.g4
- **Carlsbad Variation** D17
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 -> 6.Ne5 Nbd7 7.Nxc4 Qc7 8.g3 e5
  - **Morozevich Variation** D17
    1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5 6.Ne5 Nbd7 7.Nxc4 Qc7 8.g3 e5 -> 9.dxe5 Nxe5 10.Bf4 Nfd7 11…
- **Smyslov Variation** D16
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Na6
- **Soultanbeieff Variation** D16
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 e6
- **Steiner Variation** D16
  1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 -> 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bg4

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3 dxc4 5.a4 Bf5
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> Bg5 -> e3
Black	d5 -> e6 -> Nf6 -> Be7 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.

2. White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.

3. White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

Pawn structure in one line

c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.